

LEADER HUDDLES

52 Huddle Guides · Southeast Students

2026–2027

© 2026 Southeast Students. All Rights Reserved.
No portion of this book may be reproduced in any form
without permission from the publisher, except as permitted by U.S. copyright law.

Scripture quotations are taken from the Holy Bible, New Living Translation (NLT).

For permissions contact:
Justin Davis · jdavis@secc.org

WHAT'S INSIDE

CONTENTS

00	**Best Practices** SHORT, WORTH IT, AND PLANNED	—
01	**Leadership** WHO YOU ARE BEFORE WHAT YOU DO	07
02	**Leading Groups** DRAWING EVERY STUDENT IN	23
03	**Care** TENDING SOULS—INCLUDING YOURS	39
04	**Prayer Moments** GUIDED MOMENTS THAT FUEL THE WORK	53
05	**Mission & Outreach** WE GATHER TO SCATTER	67
06	**Discipleship & Spiritual Growth** GROWING DEEP, NOT JUST BUSY	83
07	**Skills & Training** SHARPENING THE CRAFT OF LEADING	99
08	**Vision & Culture** THE WHY BENEATH THE WHAT	113

00

SECTION 00

BEST PRACTICES

Short, worth it, and planned.

BEST PRACTICES

A HUDDLE IS...

HUD·DLE · NOUN

A brief gathering of players during a game to receive instruction.

Nobody huddles in the locker room—that's a pregame speech. Nobody huddles in the parking lot afterward—that's a debrief. A huddle happens on the field, in the middle of the game. It lasts seconds. Then everybody breaks and runs the play.

When you pull your leaders together before MSM or HSM, understand what you're doing: you're taking them off the field, mid-game, while students are walking in the door. That's worth it on two conditions: 1) It has to be short, 2) it has to be worth it.

> **Every minute a huddle runs long is a minute a leader isn't connecting with a student.**

Huddles are the most consistent, repeatable time you will ever have with the adults discipling students at your campus. More than trainings. More than the Big 3. Which means the question is: **where am I leading these people by May?** A semester of announcements takes your leaders nowhere. A semester you planned moves them.

On the following page, consider what a planned semester of huddles looks like. Creating a rhythm decides where you're taking your leaders; the huddle delivers it.

AN EXAMPLE, NOT A MANDATE

A PLANNED FALL

AUG	01	COMMUNITY	VIS-01	Why We Exist
	02	COMMUNITY	DSC-01	Be the Branch
	03	CARE	LDR-01	The Heart of a Shepherd
SEP	04	CARE	SKL-01	Names & the First Five Minutes
	05	EQUIPPING	LGR-06	Preparing to Lead a Group
	06	EQUIPPING	LGR-02	Asking Better Questions
	07	EQUIPPING	LGR-01	The Quiet One & The Talker
OCT	08	EQUIPPING	LGR-03	The Four Chairs Overview
	09	MISSION	MIS-01	Who's Your One?
	10	MISSION	MIS-03	Showing Up at Their School
	11	MISSION	PRY-05	Praying for Your One
NOV	12	MISSION	MIS-05	The Invite Habit
	13	RETREAT	CAR-01	Running on Empty
	14	COMMUNITY	CAR-02	You're Not Alone
	15	COMMUNITY	PRY-06	Gratitude Round
DEC	16	COMMUNITY	CAR-03	Celebrating Wins
	17	RETREAT	DSC-07	Ministry Is for You, Not Just Them

RHYTHMS KEY COMMUNITY · EQUIPPING · MISSION · CARE · RETREAT

BEST PRACTICES

LITTLE THINGS THAT MAKE IT WORK

01 **Start on time, end on time.**

Fifteen minutes. Long huddles aren't more valuable, just longer.

02 **Sit together.**

Circle up. A huddle delivered from the front is a briefing.

03 **Put it on the screen.**

Getting visual clarifies your words for the room.

04 **Don't reread your leader email.**

If you send weekly communications, don't reshare what you already said.

05 **Protect the physical.**

Move what can be digital to digital. In-person time is relational, not informational.

06 **Know your win for the day.**

Do you want to inspire? Encourage? Care? Equip? Celebrate? Pick a lane and stay in it or you risk purpose whiplash.

07 **Notice who's not there.**

Leaders who skip huddle need followed up with. Things happen, but regular misses means they either aren't Available or need accountability to be Faithful.

01

SECTION 01

LEADERSHIP

Who you are before what you do.

IN THIS SECTION

HUDDLES ON LEADERSHIP

LDR-01	The Heart of a Shepherd	09
LDR-02	Leading by Example	11
LDR-03	Culture Carrier	13
LDR-04	Caught, Not Taught	15
LDR-05	Faithful in the Small Things	17
LDR-06	Leading When You're Not Feeling It	19
LDR-07	Humility Over Hype	21

LDR-01 THE HEART OF A SHEPHERD

MANTRA **BE THE BRANCH** RHYTHM **CARE**

BIG IDEA

You're not a group leader; you're a shepherd—and shepherds lead by example, not obligation.

1 PETER 5:2-4 NLT

Care for the flock that God has entrusted to you. Watch over it willingly, not grudgingly—not for what you will get out of it, but because you are eager to serve God. Don't lord it over the people assigned to your care, but lead them by your own good example. And when the Great Shepherd appears, you will receive a crown of never-ending glory and honor.

LEADER NOTES

Sets the tone for the leader's identity—good early in a semester.



OPEN 2 MIN

Who was a leader who shaped you—a coach, teacher, or mentor? In one word, what made them worth following?

CORE 8 MIN

Read 1 Peter 5:2-4 together. Peter gives three contrasts: willing not grudging, eager not greedy, example not domineering. Ask: which of those three is hardest for you right now? A shepherd's authority isn't a title—it's earned by being a branch connected to the vine (Be the Branch). We value connection to Jesus over production for Jesus, and connection to students over just running the program. Quick gut-check: this week, did students experience you as someone leading by example, or someone getting through a program?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray in pairs. Ask God to make each of you a shepherd who leads willingly and eagerly this week—and name one student you want to watch over better.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, do one thing that's shepherding, not programming—a text, a follow-up, showing up somewhere for a student outside of group.

LDR-02 LEADING BY EXAMPLE

MANTRA **GRIP THE PLOW** RHYTHM **EQUIPPING**

BIG IDEA

Your students will copy what you do long before they follow what you say—so set the pace.

1 CORINTHIANS 11:1 NLT

And you should imitate me, just as I imitate Christ.

LEADER NOTES

Good early-semester or when you're onboarding newer leaders. Keep the gut-check safe, not guilt-heavy.



OPEN 2 MIN

Finish this sentence out loud: 'I picked up a habit—good or bad—from someone I looked up to, and it was ___.' Quick and honest.

CORE 8 MIN

Paul doesn't say 'listen to me.' He says 'imitate me—because I'm imitating Christ.' That's a bold claim, and it's the whole job. Your students are watching how you handle your phone in group, how you talk about the kid who isn't there, whether you actually show up early. You set the pace whether you mean to or not. Grip the Plow means intentional, focused effort—not just being present, but leaning in. Gut-check: if a student copied your walk with Jesus exactly this week, where would they end up? Not to shame you—to aim you. Pick the one area where you'd want them to imitate you least, and name it.

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray in pairs. Ask God to make your life worth imitating this week—and name the one area you just flagged, asking Him to grow you there.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, do one thing on purpose because a student is watching—show up early, own a mistake out loud, or open your Bible unplanned in front of them.

LDR-03 CULTURE CARRIER

MANTRA **CATCH THE WIND** RHYTHM **COMMUNITY**

BIG IDEA

Culture isn't set by the rules on the wall—it's set by the leaders worth following in the room.

1 THESSALONIANS 1:6-7 NLT

So you received the message with joy from the Holy Spirit in spite of the severe suffering it brought you. In this way, you imitated both us and the Lord. As a result, you have become an example to all the believers in Greece—throughout both Macedonia and Achaia.

LEADER NOTES

Vision-flavored but practical—good when a group's culture feels flat or cliquey. Keep it hopeful, not scolding.

OPEN 2 MIN

In one word, what does the culture of your group feel like on a good night? Now—what do you want it to feel like?

CORE 8 MIN

Paul says the Thessalonians imitated him, and then became the example everyone else copied. Culture spread—leader to disciple to whole region. That's how it works in your group too. You don't announce culture; you carry it. The energy you bring, the way you welcome the new student, whether you're the first one talking to God and the last one to gossip—that becomes the water everyone swims in. Catch the Wind means staying open to what the Holy Spirit wants to do—risk, joy, adventure—not just managing a room. Ask the group: what's one thing you love about your group's culture, and what's one thing you'd want to change? Then the harder one: are you carrying the culture you want, or just tolerating the one you have?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for the Holy Spirit to fill your group with the kind of joy the Thessalonians had—even through hard stuff. Ask God to make each of you a carrier, not just a bystander.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Name one culture move you'll make this week—greet every student by name, kill one habit of complaining, or bring the energy first instead of waiting for it.

LDR-04 CAUGHT, NOT TAUGHT

MANTRA **GRIP THE PLOW** RHYTHM **EQUIPPING**

BIG IDEA

You don't develop students with a lecture—you develop them by letting them watch you, then handing off next steps one at a time.

2 TIMOTHY 2:2 NLT

You have heard me teach things that have been confirmed by many reliable witnesses. Now teach these truths to other trustworthy people who will be able to pass them on to others.

LEADER NOTES

Core development huddle—pairs well with recruiting or when student leaders are coming online.



OPEN 2 MIN

Think of one thing you're actually good at. Did you learn it from watching someone and then trying it yourself? Or did you magically figure it out yourself?

CORE 8 MIN

Paul's whole plan for the next generation fits in one verse: what you caught from me, hand to someone who can hand it to someone else. Leadership is caught, not taught. That's why we use a ladder instead of a lecture: (1) I do, you watch, we talk. (2) I do, you help, we talk. (3) You do, I help, we talk. (4) You do, I watch, we talk. (5) You do. Most of us get stuck on rung one forever—we do it all and never move students up. Gripping the Plow means intentional handoff, not just carrying the whole load yourself. Pick one real task—leading a discussion question, praying to close, texting a student who missed. Which rung is your student on for that task right now, and what's the next rung?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for one specific student leader you're developing by name. Ask God for the patience to hand off and the trust to let go.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, help move one person up one rung. Tell them the plan so they see the handoff coming.

LDR-05

FAITHFUL IN THE SMALL THINGS

MANTRA **BE THE BRANCH** RHYTHM **CARE**

BIG IDEA

The unseen, unglamorous, show-up-anyway stuff is the real work—and God's watching all of it.

LUKE 16:10 NLT

If you are faithful in little things, you will be faithful in large ones. But if you are dishonest in little things, you won't be honest with greater responsibilities.

LEADER NOTES

An encouragement/care week—good for a tired team mid-semester. This is where you honor the quiet workhorses. Keep it warm; this isn't a productivity push, it's a 'God sees you' huddle.



OPEN 2 MIN

What's the least glamorous part of leading students that you do anyway? Say it out loud—folding chairs counts.

CORE 8 MIN

Jesus flips how we measure faithfulness. We think the big moments count—the retreat where a student gives their life to Christ, the perfect talk. Jesus says the small stuff is the test: showing up when you're tired, remembering a name, following up on the text nobody would've noticed you skipped. Nobody claps for the small things. But that's where character gets built, and it's where students actually feel loved—one at a time. Being the Branch is connection over production; the small faithful stuff is connection. Ask honestly: where have you been faithful in the small things lately? And where have you been quietly cutting corners because you figured no one would notice? God notices—not to catch you, but because He counts it.

PRAYER 3 MIN

Thank God for the small, unseen faithfulness in the room—name a few out loud. Ask Him for the endurance to stay faithful where no one's watching.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, do the small faithful thing you're tempted to skip—the follow-up text, staying late to follow up with a student, noticing a student's growth in group. Do it anyway.

LDR-06

LEADING WHEN YOU'RE NOT FEELING IT

MANTRA **GRIP THE PLOW** RHYTHM **EQUIPPING**

BIG IDEA

Ministry runs on obedience, not motivation—and the harvest comes to the ones who don't quit.

GALATIANS 6:9 NLT

So let's not get tired of doing what is good. At just the right time we will reap a harvest of blessing if we don't give up.

LEADER NOTES

Best mid-semester or in a grind stretch (post-camp, exam season). If a leader is clearly past 'unmotivated' and into burnout, follow up 1-on-1—this huddle isn't a fix for burnout, and don't guilt someone who needs rest.

OPEN 2 MIN

Be honest—did you drive here tonight fired up, or running on fumes? No wrong answer. Just a gut read.

CORE 8 MIN

Some weeks you'll feel it. Most weeks you won't. Paul doesn't say 'lead when you're inspired'—he says 'don't get tired of doing good,' which means he assumes you'll get tired. The feeling isn't the fuel. Obedience is. Grip the Plow: Jesus said the one who puts their hand to the plow and keeps looking back isn't fit for the work—you keep the row straight even when the excitement's gone. That's not white-knuckling; it's trusting that the harvest comes 'at just the right time' if you don't give up. Ask the group: what's the thing you're tempted to phone in right now because the feeling faded? And what would it look like to show up faithful this week even if the motivation never comes back?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for the leaders in the room running on empty. Ask God for a second wind—and for the obedience to keep going even before it comes.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Pick the one thing you've been dragging on and do it fully this week—not because you feel like it, but because you said you would.

LDR-07 HUMILITY OVER HYPE

MANTRA **EMPTY THE JAR** RHYTHM **COMMUNITY**

BIG IDEA

It was never about you—the best leaders make it about the students and about Jesus, not the highlight reel.

PHILIPPIANS 2:3-4 NLT

Don't be selfish; don't try to impress others. Be humble, thinking of others as better than yourselves. Don't look out only for your own interests, but take an interest in others, too.

LEADER NOTES

A heart-check huddle—good when a team is getting a little performance-driven or a little competitive. Keep the open question internal, not a public confession. HSM tweak: high school leaders can feel real pressure to be the 'cool' leader—name that directly.



OPEN 2 MIN

Quick gut-check: when ministry goes great or your student accepts Christ, whose name do you secretly want attached to it? Just notice it—don't confess it out loud.

CORE 8 MIN

There's a version of student ministry that's really about the leader—the funniest one, the one the cool kids love, the one running the show. Paul kills that quietly: don't try to impress, count others as more important, look out for their interests. Servant leadership isn't weak leadership; it's the opposite of hype. The woman who broke the jar poured out everything with no eye on who was watching (Empty the Jar)—that's the posture. Ask honestly: where's the hunger for hype showing up in you—needing the credit, the favorite-leader status, the win being yours? And what would it look like to lead so that Jesus and the students get bigger while you get smaller? The win was never 'they loved me.' It's 'a student took a next step toward Christ.'

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for humble hearts—that God would grow in each of you the willingness to be unseen so students get seen and Jesus gets glory. Confess any hunger for hype silently to Him.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, do one thing for a student that no one will ever know you did—no post, no mention, no credit.

02

SECTION 02

LEADING GROUPS

Drawing every student in.

IN THIS SECTION

HUDDLES ON LEADING GROUPS

LGR-01	The Quiet One & The Talker	25
LGR-02	Asking Better Questions	27
LGR-03	The Four Chairs Overview	29
LGR-04	When Conversations Go Sideways	31
LGR-05	Silence Is Your Friend	33
LGR-06	Preparing to Lead a Group	35
LGR-07	Following Up Between Groups	37

LGR-01 THE QUIET ONE & THE TALKER

RHYTHM **EQUIPPING** DISCIPLINE **COMMUNITY**

BIG IDEA

A good group isn't the one where you talk the most—it's the one where everyone gets drawn in.

JAMES 1:19 NLT

Understand this, my dear brothers and sisters: You must all be quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to get angry.

LEADER NOTES

Practical skill huddle—the role-play makes it stick, don't skip it. HSM tweak: add handling the student who derails with jokes.



OPEN 2 MIN

In your group, who talks the most—and who's easiest to overlook? No shaming, just name it in your head.

CORE 8 MIN

If you are the talker, it's time to recognize that your job is facilitator, not lecturer. But every group has a talker and a quiet one. Your job is to move the conversation around so everyone begins to participate. You can't do that if the same two voices fill every silence. Three quick tools: (1) Ask, then wait—count to seven in your head before rescuing the silence. (2) Go around the circle sometimes so quiet students know their turn is coming and safe. (3) Redirect the talker with honor: 'Love that—let's hear from someone who hasn't gone yet.' Consider role playing if your people are up for it.

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray by name for the one or two students in your group who are hardest to draw out. Ask God to help them feel seen this week.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Next group, use the count-to-seven pause at least twice, and directly invite one quiet student into the conversation by name.

LGR-02 ASKING BETTER QUESTIONS

MANTRA **CATCH THE WIND** RHYTHM **EQUIPPING**

BIG IDEA

The right question opens a student up faster than the best answer ever could—Jesus asked constantly.

MARK 10:51 NLT

"What do you want me to do for you?" Jesus asked. "My Rabbi," the blind man said, "I want to see!"

LEADER NOTES

Practical skills week—the turn-it-into-open-questions drill is the point, don't skip it. MSM tweak: middle schoolers need shorter, more concrete open questions ('What's the scariest thing at your school?')—abstract ones get blank stares.



OPEN 2 MIN

What's a question someone once asked you that actually made you think? Not a lesson—a question.

CORE 8 MIN

Jesus already knew the blind man wanted to see. He asked anyway—'What do you want me to do for you?'—because a good question invites a person to open up instead of just receiving. We rush to give answers; Jesus made space with questions. Here's the tool: closed questions have one right answer and end the conversation ('Was David scared?'). Open questions have no single right answer and start one ('When have you been that scared?'). Closed questions test; open questions invite. Stacking open questions alongside partnership with the Holy Spirit will unlock new territory for your group. Practice now: take one closed question—'Do you pray?'—and as a group, turn it into three open ones. Then do it again with a passage we're covering this week.

PRAYER 3 MIN

Ask God to make you curious about your students—genuinely interested, not just fishing for the 'right' answer. Pray for the Holy Spirit to lead you as you lead the group conversation.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Next group, catch yourself before every closed question and open it up. Aim to ask more than you tell. When in doubt, call on the Holy Spirit for help!

LGR-03 THE FOUR CHAIRS OVERVIEW

RHYTHM **EQUIPPING**

BIG IDEA

Every student is sitting in one of four chairs—your job is to know which, and help them take the next step.

1 JOHN 2:6 NLT

Those who say they live in God must live their lives as Jesus did.

LEADER NOTES

Core discipleship-pathway huddle—the roster-marking makes it real, don't skip it. Remind leaders the chairs aren't a ranking of worth, they're a map.

OPEN 2 MIN

Picture one specific student in your group. In your head, is that student more 'still figuring out if this is real' or 'all in and ready to lead'? Hold that thought.

CORE 8 MIN

Discipleship isn't one-size-fits-all—students are in different chairs, and each chair requires a response to the challenge Jesus gave. Quick overview: **Chair 1**, Come & See—lost or exploring, not sure about Jesus. **Chair 2**, Follow Me—a believer, following Jesus. **Chair 3**, Fish for People—equipped and starting to serve. **Chair 4**, Bear Fruit—a disciple-maker, pouring into others. 1 John says the goal is to 'live as Jesus did'—Jesus met people right where they sat and moved them one challenge at a time. He didn't hand a Chair 1 student a leadership role, and he didn't leave a Chair 3 student sitting on their hands. Now do the work: have each leader take their roster and quickly mark a chair number next to each student. Then pick two to assign a single next-step for each. Identifying is the first part; the action is the win.

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray over your roster. Ask God for wisdom to see where each student really is and courage to take the next step with them.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, take the one next-step action for the two students you named. Real fruit might be this week, but also unseen in years to come. This tiny action is a part of the redemption story for those God gives us to shepherd.

LGR-04

WHEN CONVERSATIONS GO SIDEWAYS

RHYTHM **EQUIPPING**

BIG IDEA

When a group goes off the rails—controversial, off-topic, or heavy—grace and steadiness matter more than the perfect answer.

COLOSSIANS 4:6 NLT

Let your conversation be gracious and attractive so that you will have the right response for everyone.

LEADER NOTES

Important safety/skills huddle. Make sure every leader knows our escalation path for disclosures (abuse, self-harm)—this is not optional and not peer-led guesswork.



OPEN 2 MIN

Think: What's a question or comment from a student that once caught you totally off guard? You don't have to say how you handled it.

CORE 8 MIN

It'll happen: a student drops a controversial take, derails onto something wild, or says something heavy that stops the room. Your instinct is to shut it down or win the argument. Paul says lead with grace—'gracious and attractive'—so you have the right response for everyone. Three moves. (1) Off-topic: honor it, then steer. 'Good rabbit trail—let's come back to it after, I want to hear the rest.' (2) Controversial: get curious before you correct. 'Tell me more about why you see it that way' buys you truth and trust. (3) Heavy—abuse, self-harm, real pain: don't fix it in the circle. Slow down, stay calm, and take it 1-on-1, then loop in your Team Leader or staff. You don't have to have the answer; you have to be safe. Practice one: someone plays a student with a spicy take, and a leader practices getting curious instead of correcting.

PRAYER 3 MIN

Ask God for gracious, steady hearts—and for the wisdom to know when to steer, when to get curious, and when to slow down and get assistance. Pray for any student you already know is carrying something heavy.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, if the conversation goes sideways, lead with one question instead of one correction. And review our Stoplight Training to refresh yourself.

LGR-05 SILENCE IS YOUR FRIEND

RHYTHM **EQUIPPING**

BIG IDEA

The awkward pause isn't a problem to fix—it's the moment a student finally decides to speak.

ECCLESIASTES 3:7 NLT

A time to tear and a time to mend. A time to be quiet and a time to speak.

LEADER NOTES

Short, high-impact skills huddle—the ten-second silence drill is uncomfortable and completely necessary, don't cut it. MSM tweak: middle schoolers need slightly shorter waits and more permission ('there's no wrong answer here') before they'll fill the pause.



OPEN 2 MIN

On a scale of 1 to 10, how uncomfortable does silence in your group make you? Just a number.

CORE 8 MIN

There's 'a time to be quiet.' Most of us can't stand it. You ask a question, nobody answers, and after two seconds you panic and rescue it—you answer your own question, or reword it three times, or move on. Here's the truth: the student who was about to speak just got let off the hook. The silence wasn't dead air; it was a kid working up the nerve, or actually thinking. When you rescue silence, you train your group that they never have to answer—you'll always fill it. So don't. Ask the question once. Then wait. Look around thoughtfully to show you're willing to wait. The pause belongs to them. Practice now: someone asks a real question, and the whole group sits in ten full seconds of silence. Feel how long that actually is—that's the point.

PRAYER 3 MIN

Ask God for the self-control to stay quiet and trust the pause. Pray for the specific students who only speak when you make space for them.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Ask your question once and then count to ten before you say another word. Let the silence do its job at least twice. If still no one speaks up, change the question (everyone answers, yes/no) to get momentum.

LGR-06 PREPARING TO LEAD A GROUP

RHYTHM **EQUIPPING**

BIG IDEA

Fifteen minutes of prep is the difference between winging it and actually leading —and it's simpler than you think.

2 TIMOTHY 3:16-17 NLT

All Scripture is inspired by God and is useful to teach us what is true and to make us realize what is wrong in our lives. It corrects us when we are wrong and teaches us to do what is right. God uses it to prepare and equip his people to do every good work.

LEADER NOTES

Foundational skills huddle—great for new leaders or leaders that have been winging it. Consider handing out the Open/Read/Discuss/Pray steps on a card and pointing to the content booklet.



OPEN 2 MIN

Be honest—how much do you usually prep before group: a lot, a little, or 'I read the question in the parking lot'? No judgment.

CORE 8 MIN

You don't need a seminary degree to prep—you need a rhythm. Paul says Scripture itself equips you for the good work; your job is just to show up ready to let it. Here's the whole prep in four steps, about fifteen minutes: **OPEN**—read the passage and the questions once, early in the week, not in the car. **READ**—read it again slower and ask 'what's this actually about?' so you're not surprised. **DISCUSS**—pick the two or three questions that matter most and think about how your specific students might answer. **PRAY**—pray through your roster before you ever walk in. That's it. Prep isn't about having every answer; it's about not being caught flat-footed so you can actually be present with students. Ask your leaders: which of those four do you skip most, and what would it take to build the fifteen-minute rhythm into your week?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Ask God to make His Word come alive in your prep this week—and to prepare your heart before you ever prepare your talking points. Pray for the discipline to build the rhythm.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Before next group, run the fifteen-minute Open/Read/Discuss/Pray rhythm once—earlier in the week than you normally would. Bonus: write down a few of your own questions that come to mind.

LGR-07

FOLLOWING UP BETWEEN GROUPS

RHYTHM **CARE**

BIG IDEA

The thirty minutes to an hour during groups matters—but the six days between are where students actually feel known.

1 THESSALONIANS 2:8 NLT

We loved you so much that we shared with you not only God's Good News but our own lives, too.

LEADER NOTES

Care-flavored skills huddle—pairs well with LGR-03 (chairs) and PRY-01 (roster prayer). MSM tweak: for middle schoolers, most follow-up should route through parents (text the parent, show up at the game)—keep it visible and appropriate, never 1-on-1 private DMs. HSM tweak: once high schoolers can drive, your options open up, but still follow our safety guidelines.



OPEN 2 MIN

When did an adult reach out to you outside of a program—just because? How did that land?

CORE 8 MIN

Paul didn't just deliver a message; he shared his life. That's the difference between running a group and discipling students. The truth nobody tells new leaders: the week matters more than the hour. A student can sit in your circle every week and still feel like a number if you never exist in their life the other six days. Following up is how a student moves from attending church to spiritual growth—they start to believe you actually like them, not just their attendance. It doesn't take much: a two-line text encouraging them, showing up at one game or recital, a 'praying for you this week' with no agenda. Connection to Jesus and one another happens between groups, not just in them. Ask the group: who's one student you see every week but have never contacted between groups? What's one small reach-out you could make this week?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray by name for the students who need to feel pursued, not just present. Ask God to help you share your life, not just run a group.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, reach out to one student between groups—a text, a show-up, a no-agenda check-in. Bonus: invite them to join you in something you already have planned (grocery, coffee run, pickleball, the movies, dinner).

03

SECTION 03

CARE

Tending souls—including yours.

IN THIS SECTION

HUDDLES ON CARE

CAR-01	Running on Empty	41
CAR-02	You're Not Alone	43
CAR-03	Celebrating Wins	45
CAR-04	When a Student Breaks Your Heart	47
CAR-05	Healthy Boundaries	49
CAR-06	Sabbath & Rhythm	51

CAR-01 RUNNING ON EMPTY

RHYTHM **RETREAT**

BIG IDEA

You can't pour into students if you're running on empty—Jesus himself pulled away to rest.

MARK 6:31 NLT

Then Jesus said, 'Let's go off by ourselves to a quiet place and rest awhile.' He said this because there were so many people coming and going that they didn't even have time to eat.

LEADER NOTES

A care/refuel week—good before or after a heavy stretch (camp, retreat, semester). Keep it safe; if a leader is clearly burned out, follow up 1-on-1 after.

OPEN 2 MIN

On a scale of 1 (empty) to 10 (full), where's your tank this week? Just a number, no explanation needed.

CORE 8 MIN

Notice: Jesus called his disciples to rest at their busiest, most fruitful moment—not their slowest. Ministry doesn't slow down to give you permission to rest; you have to take it. Ask honestly: what's draining you right now, and where have you been ignoring your own tank? Rest isn't laziness—it's obedience and it's fuel (this is why we have the 'Eremos Place' Solitary Retreat guide). Leaders don't have to fake being full. Let people who scored low actually say so—this team is one of the places you get cared for, not just where you care for others.

PRAYER 3 MIN

Have each leader who scored low raise their hand. The rest of the group prays over them by name—for rest, refilling, and God's strength this week.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Block one real extended 'quiet place' this week—no less than 30 minutes, phone away, with God. Put it on your calendar before you leave tonight.

CAR-02 YOU'RE NOT ALONE

MANTRA **BE THE BRANCH** RHYTHM **COMMUNITY**

BIG IDEA

Leading students alone is a slow way to burn out—God built you for a team, not solo ministry.

ECCLESIASTES 4:9-10 NLT

Two people are better off than one, for they can help each other succeed. If one person falls, the other can reach out and help. But someone who falls alone is in real trouble.

LEADER NOTES

Low prep. Good for a team that's grinding or a newer team still learning to trust each other. If someone shares something heavy, follow up 1-on-1 after.

OPEN 2 MIN

Think: When's the last time another leader on this team had your back—carried something so you didn't have to?

CORE 8 MIN

Two are better than one. Not because it's more efficient—because when one falls, the other reaches down. A lot of us lead like we're supposed to have it together. We don't tell the team when we're struggling, when a group's not clicking, when we're running dry. That's not humility; it's isolation, and isolation is where good leaders quietly quit. Be the Branch means connection over production—and that includes connection to Jesus AND each other. This team is one of the 'one anothers' in your life. So practice it: what do you need as a teammate? And the reverse, what can you do as a teammate to others?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pair up. Each of you name one thing you're carrying right now. Then pray for your partner by name—that they wouldn't carry it alone, and that this team would be a place we carry burdens together.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, if you find yourself carrying weight alone, tell one person on this team what you're carrying. This isn't about fixing it—its about locking arms and walking together.

CAR-03 CELEBRATING WINS

RHYTHM **COMMUNITY**

BIG IDEA

Heaven throws a party over one student stepping toward Jesus—don't rush past what makes God celebrate.

LUKE 15:7 NLT

In the same way, there is more joy in heaven over one lost sinner who repents and returns to God than over ninety-nine others who are righteous and haven't strayed away!

LEADER NOTES

Low prep, high morale. Great after a hard stretch or when the team feels like nothing's working. MSM/HSM tweak: for MSM, 'wins' are often smaller and behavioral (a kid stayed in the circle, made eye contact)—coach leaders not to wait for HSM-sized breakthroughs.

OPEN 2 MIN

One good thing that happened in your group in the last month—a moment, a comment, a student who showed up. Say it fast, don't overthink it.

CORE 8 MIN

Heaven throws a party over one. Not a program launch, not a full room—one student turning toward God. We tend to rush past that. We finish a night already thinking about next week, already listing what went wrong. But the win is: a student takes a next step toward Christ. That's the whole thing. If heaven stops to celebrate one, we can too. So slow down and name them out loud: Where did you actually see God move this month? A guarded kid opened up. A student prayed for the first time. Somebody came back who you thought was gone. When we don't name wins, leaders forget why they're here—and we start measuring the wrong stuff.

PRAYER 3 MIN

Go around and have each leader thank God out loud for one specific student win—by name if you can. Let it feel like a party, not a report.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, tell one student directly that you noticed a step they took. Name the win to their face.

CAR-04

WHEN A STUDENT BREAKS YOUR HEART

MANTRA **WRECK THE ROOF** RHYTHM **CARE**

BIG IDEA

You will carry hard student stories—but you were never meant to carry them by yourself.

ROMANS 12:15 NLT

Be happy with those who are happy, and weep with those who weep.

LEADER NOTES

This can go deep fast—leave margin and don't force sharing. If a student situation involves harm or safety, remind leaders of the reporting/staff escalation path.

OPEN 2 MIN

You don't have to share details—but is there a student whose story is weighing on you right now? A raised hand is enough.

CORE 8 MIN

Weep with those who weep. If you lead students long enough, one of them will break your heart—a home falling apart, a hospital, a choice you couldn't talk them out of, a kid who walked away. That's not a sign you're doing it wrong. That's what love costs. Wreck the Roof is loving one at a time, and one at a time means their pain gets close to you. But here's the trap: you carry it alone, you replay it at 2am, and slowly you go numb to protect yourself. Don't do that. Weeping over someone's lostness is holy. Carrying it alone is not sustainable. Two questions tonight: What's the heaviest story you're holding? And who—leader, staff, God—are you actually handing it to?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for the students behind the heaviness in this room—no names required. Then pray for each other: that God would carry what you can't, and that no one leaves here holding it alone.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, hand one heavy student story to God AND to one other person—your Team Leader, staff, or a trusted friend. Say it out loud to someone.

CAR-05 HEALTHY BOUNDARIES

RHYTHM **CARE**

BIG IDEA

You are not the Savior—and the most loving leaders know when to pull away.

MARK 1:35-38 NLT

Before daybreak the next morning, Jesus got up and went out to an isolated place to pray. Later Simon and the others went out to find him. When they found him, they said, 'Everyone is looking for you.' But Jesus replied, 'We must go on to other towns as well, and I will preach to them, too. That is why I came.'

LEADER NOTES

Ties directly to safe-ministry practices—reinforce our policies on 1-on-1 contact, texting minors, and looping in parents/staff.

OPEN 2 MIN

Be honest: do you find it harder to say yes to students, or to say no? One word.

CORE 8 MIN

There's a line in this passage most of us skip: 'Everyone is looking for you.' There was still a crowd. Still need. Still people who wanted more of Jesus. And Jesus pulled away to pray, then moved on. He didn't meet every need in Capernaum—on purpose. Sit with that. If Jesus didn't say yes to everyone, you can't either. When you make yourself endlessly available—absorbing every crisis, being the one a student calls before their parents, allowing a student to dictate your time around program each week—it feels like love, but it teaches students to lean on you instead of on Christ. You're not the Savior. Boundaries aren't the opposite of care; they're what make care last. Two gut-checks: Where are you playing a role only Jesus can play? And what's one 'no' that would actually be healthy?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for freedom—that each leader could release the students they've been trying to save, back into God's hands. Ask God for wisdom to know the yes's and the no's this week.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Name one boundary you'll set this week—a situation you'll route to staff or parents, a yes you'll turn into a no, a challenge to seek Christ instead of others. Say it out loud before you leave.

CAR-06 SABBATH & RHYTHM

RHYTHM **RETREAT**

BIG IDEA

Rest is a discipline you practice, not a reward you earn once everything's done.

MATTHEW 11:28-30 NLT

Then Jesus said, 'Come to me, all of you who are weary and carry heavy burdens, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you. Let me teach you, because I am humble and gentle at heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For my yoke is easy to bear, and the burden I give you is light.'

LEADER NOTES

Pairs well with CAR-01 (Running on Empty) but goes further—this is about a repeatable rhythm, not a one-time refuel. Reference the Eremos Place Solitary Retreat guide for leaders ready to go deeper.

OPEN 2 MIN

When did you last take a real sabbath—no ministry, no side hustle, no work? We aren't judging the answer. Just notice it.

CORE 8 MIN

Most of us treat rest like a reward: I'll rest when the semester ends, when camp's over, when I catch up. Here's the problem—you never catch up. Jesus doesn't say 'come to me when you've earned a break.' He says come now, weary and loaded down, and He gives rest. Sabbath is a rhythm God built into the week on purpose, before anyone was tired. It's a discipline, like prayer or reading Scripture—something you practice whether you feel like you deserve it or not. And it's an act of trust: taking a day off says the ministry, the students, the world will keep running because God runs it, not you. The 'Eremos Place' retreat guide exists for exactly this. Two questions: What rhythm of rest do you actually have—not wish you had? And what's one thing you'd need to trust God with to take a real day off?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray Matthew 11:28 back to God, out loud, as a group: 'We're weary. We're carrying heavy burdens. We're coming to you.' Then a moment of silence—actually rest in it for 30 seconds before you close.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Block one Sabbath rhythm this week and defend it—a full day, an evening, a morning. Put it on the calendar before you leave tonight.

04

SECTION 04

PRAYER MOMENTS

Guided moments that fuel the work.

IN THIS SECTION

HUDDLES ON PRAYER MOMENTS

PRY-01	Praying Your Roster by Name	55
PRY-02	Listening Prayer	57
PRY-03	Praying Scripture	59
PRY-04	Fasting, Simply	61
PRY-05	Praying for Your One	63
PRY-06	Gratitude Round	65

PRY-01

PRAYING YOUR ROSTER BY NAME

RHYTHM COMMUNITY | RHYTHM CARE

BIG IDEA

Before Jesus chose the Twelve, he prayed all night—investing in a few starts on your knees.

LUKE 6:12-13 NLT

One day soon afterward Jesus went up on a mountain to pray, and he prayed to God all night. At daybreak he called together all of his disciples and chose twelve of them to be apostles.

LEADER NOTES

A prayer-forward, low-prep week—flip the usual ratio so prayer gets the most time. Pairs well after a recruiting or invite push.



OPEN 2 MIN

Off the top of your head—can you name every student in your group right now? Try it silently. Do you have a clear understanding between your co-leaders about relational connections?

CORE 6 MIN

Jesus invested in a few, and it started with a whole night of prayer. Tonight we practice that rhythm on a small scale. Partnering with your co-leader, have each leader write out their student roster—every name. Next to each, mark where they are: no relationship yet (new or unconnected), acquaintance (around, but fringe), friendship (regular, known), or being discipled by you (your few). That's not a scorecard; it's a prayer map. Are there any gaps in students who are getting little to no relational connection? Are there students getting all our attention and we need to give some away to another?

PRAYER 5 MIN

Spend the bulk of huddle actually praying the rosters—for students who need deeper relational connections.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Spread out your relational investment amongst your group. But take a cue from Jesus and claim your few. If you and your co-leaders have the same "few" then have some conversations about who is investing where.

PRY-02 LISTENING PRAYER

MANTRA **CATCH THE WIND** | RHYTHM **RETREAT** | DISCIPLINE **PRAYER**

BIG IDEA

God often speaks in the whisper—but you have to get quiet enough to hear it.

1 KINGS 19:11-12 NLT

'Go out and stand before me on the mountain,' the LORD told him. And as Elijah stood there, the LORD passed by, and a mighty windstorm hit the mountain. It was such a terrible blast that the rocks were torn loose, but the LORD was not in the wind. After the wind there was an earthquake, but the LORD was not in the earthquake. And after the earthquake there was a fire, but the LORD was not in the fire. And after the fire there was the sound of a gentle whisper.

LEADER NOTES

Prayer-forward—prayer gets the most minutes on purpose. Very low prep. First time will feel long; that's normal. Reassure people that 'hearing nothing' isn't failure—being with God is the win.

OPEN 2 MIN

How comfortable are you with silence—like, actual quiet, no phone, no noise? Thumbs up, sideways, or down.

CORE 4 MIN

Elijah was looking for God in the big stuff—wind, earthquake, fire. God wasn't there. He came in a whisper. Most of our prayer is us talking. Tonight we flip it and practice listening. This is Catch the Wind—making room for the Holy Spirit instead of running the show. Quieting down feels awkward at first. That's fine. We're going to be still, and we're going to trust that a God who whispers is worth getting quiet for. No agenda except this: be with Him and listen.

PRAYER 7 MIN

Guide the room: 'For the next few minutes, stop talking to God and just listen. Get comfortable. Take three slow breaths. Ask one question—God, what do you want me to hear tonight?—and then be quiet.' Sit in real silence for 5 minutes; leader keeps time so no one has to watch the clock. Then invite anyone who wants to share a word, image, or nudge they sensed. No pressure—some will, some won't, and that's fine.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, incorporate some solitude and silence into your quiet times. Take 5 minutes to listen to what the Spirit wants to draw your attention to.

PRY-03 PRAYING SCRIPTURE

RHYTHM EQUIPPING | DISCIPLINE BIBLE

BIG IDEA

When you don't know how to pray, let the Word give you the words.

PSALM 119:105 NLT

Your word is a lamp to guide my feet and a light for my path.

LEADER NOTES

Prayer-forward—most minutes go to praying. Low prep; bring Psalm 23 in NLT. This doubles as an equipping huddle: you're teaching leaders a discipline they can hand to students.

OPEN 2 MIN

Ever run out of words when you try to pray? Simple yes or no.

CORE 4 MIN

God's Word is a lamp for your feet—and it's also a script for your prayers when you're empty. Praying Scripture is old and simple: you take a verse and pray it, line by line, back to God. It keeps your prayer honest (you're praying what's true, not just what you feel), and it fuels you when you're dry. Tonight we practice with Psalm 23. You don't need to be clever—you turn the words into prayer. 'The Lord is my shepherd; I have all that I need' becomes 'God, be my shepherd this week—help me trust that you're enough.' That's it. The Word gives you the words.

PRAYER 7 MIN

Read Psalm 23 slowly, out loud, one verse at a time. After each verse, pause and let leaders pray that verse back to God—out loud or silently—over their own lives and their students. Leader models the first one so people catch the rhythm, then hands it off. Take your time; let the silences breathe.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Pick one Psalm this week—23, 27, 121, your call—and pray it line by line one morning instead of scrolling.

PRY-04

FASTING, SIMPLY

MANTRA EMPTY THE JAR | RHYTHM RETREAT | DISCIPLINE PRAYER

BIG IDEA

Fasting isn't a spiritual flex—it's quietly trading something good for more of God.

MATTHEW 6:16-18 NLT

And when you fast, don't make it obvious, as the hypocrites do, for they try to look miserable and disheveled so people will admire them for their fasting. I tell you the truth, that is the only reward they will ever get. But when you fast, comb your hair and wash your face. Then no one will notice that you are fasting, except your Father, who knows what you do in private. And your Father, who sees everything, will reward you.

LEADER NOTES

Prayer-forward and equipping—a real next-step discipline for leaders, not a lecture. Low prep. Flag any health sensitivities: never pressure anyone toward food fasting; a media/phone fast is a full, legitimate option.

OPEN 2 MIN

Be honest—what's the thing you'd have the hardest time going a day without? (Yes, your phone counts.)

CORE 4 MIN

Notice Jesus says 'when you fast,' not 'if.' He assumes His people will do it. But He kills the performance version—no showing off, no looking miserable for credit. Fasting is quiet on purpose. Here's the heart of it: you take something good, set it aside for a set time, and every time you feel the ache for it, you turn it into hunger for God. That's Empty the Jar—pouring out something valuable as worship. It doesn't have to be dramatic. Skip a meal. Fast from your phone for an evening. Give up something for a day and pray each time you miss it. Simple, private, and more powerful than most of us expect.

PRAYER 7 MIN

Give each leader a quiet minute to ask God one thing: what could I set aside this week to make more room for you? Then pray in pairs—name your simple fast to your partner (a meal, a day off the phone, coffee, whatever), and pray for each other to actually follow through and to meet God in the ache.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Pick one simple fast for this week—one meal, one evening off your phone, one thing. Each time you miss it, pray one sentence.

PRY-05

PRAYING FOR YOUR ONE

MANTRA **WRECK THE ROOF** | CHAIR **COME & SEE** | RHYTHM **MISSION** | DISCIPLINE **PRAYER**

BIG IDEA

Reaching a far-off student starts on your knees—pick one, and pray them by name.

MATTHEW 9:37-38 NLT

He said to his disciples, 'The harvest is great, but the workers are few. So pray to the Lord who is in charge of the harvest; ask him to send more workers into his fields.'

LEADER NOTES

Prayer-forward—flip the ratio so prayer carries the most time. Pairs perfectly with an invite or outreach push. The 'one' concept maps to the 4-Chairs: you're praying a Come & See student toward Follow Me. MSM/HSM tweak: MSM—'your one' is often a kid on the edge of the room who won't talk; keep the step tiny (learn their name, sit by them). HSM—'your one' may be a student actively skeptical or checked out; the step is a real conversation.

OPEN 2 MIN

Picture the one student in your orbit who's furthest from Jesus right now. Got them? Hold that face.

CORE 4 MIN

Jesus looks at a crowd of far-off people and His first move isn't a strategy—it's 'pray.' The harvest is huge, workers are few, so pray the Lord of the harvest sends someone. Here's the beautiful part: often the worker He sends is the one who prayed. Tonight, pick your one—a specific student who's in the 'Come & See' stage, not yet following Jesus, maybe not even sure why they show up. This is harvest field #1—HSM & MSM. Harvest field #2 is "out there." Who needs you to show up in their life to break through? This is Wreck the Roof: loving one at a time, refusing to let anything stop you from getting them to Jesus. Before you invite, before you strategize—you carry them to God by name.

PRAYER 7 MIN

Each leader names their one—out loud if willing, silently if not. Then spend the bulk of tonight praying for those specific students by name: for softened hearts, for open doors, for one clear next step toward Jesus, and for the leader to have eyes and courage to be the worker God sends. This is the point of the huddle, not the warm-up.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Pray your one by name every day this week—and take one small step toward them: a seat saved, ask a real question, show up in their life, lovingly challenge their indecision for Christ.

PRY-06 GRATITUDE ROUND

RHYTHM **COMMUNITY**

BIG IDEA

Thankfulness isn't a mood you wait for—it's a discipline you choose, together.

1 THESSALONIANS 5:18 NLT

Be thankful in all circumstances, for this is God's will for you who belong to Christ Jesus.

LEADER NOTES

Prayer-forward and dead-simple—great when the team is tired, discouraged, or just needs a lighter, filling week. Zero prep. Keep the round moving and specific ('my daughter laughed today,' not 'life').

OPEN 2 MIN

Quick and specific: one thing from today you're glad happened. Not big—just true.

CORE 4 MIN

'Be thankful in all circumstances.' Not for all circumstances—in them. Even in a hard week, there's something to thank God for, and Paul says finding it is literally God's will for you. Gratitude isn't a feeling that shows up on its own; it's a muscle you flex on purpose, and it changes you. Doing it together as a team is even better—thankfulness is contagious, and hearing what God's doing in each other's corner reminds everyone we're not grinding alone. Tonight is simple: no teaching to power through, no agenda. We just go around and thank God, out loud, together.

PRAYER 7 MIN

Slow, unhurried gratitude round. Go around the circle two or three times—each leader thanks God out loud for one specific thing each pass: something in their own life, something in their group, something about this team. No 'right' answers, no pressure to be profound. Let it build. Close by thanking God together for the students you get to lead.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Start a running gratitude list this week—phone note, journal, whatever. Add one specific thing a day and thank God for it.

05

SECTION 05

MISSION & OUTREACH

We gather to scatter.

IN THIS SECTION

HUDDLES ON MISSION & OUTREACH

MIS-01	Who's Your One?	69
MIS-02	Reaching the Crowd	71
MIS-03	Showing Up at Their School	73
MIS-04	Camp: Who Are You Bringing?	75
MIS-05	The Invite Habit	77
MIS-06	Your Testimony in 3 Minutes	79
MIS-07	Gathered & Scattered	81

MIS-01 WHO'S YOUR ONE?

MANTRA **WRECK THE ROOF** | CHAIR **COME & SEE** | RHYTHM **MISSION** | DISCIPLINE **EVANGELISM**

BIG IDEA

You can't reach everyone at once, but you can reach one—so who's your one?

LUKE 19:10 NLT

For the Son of Man came to seek and save those who are lost.

LEADER NOTES

Great early-semester or post-camp huddle to reset the aim on the lost. Help leaders pick a 'one' from their actual small group, not a hypothetical. Encourage naming a student at the edges—new, quiet, or drifting.

OPEN 2 MIN

Who was the one person who chased you down toward Jesus? Name them in one sentence—what did they do?

CORE 8 MIN

Jesus didn't come to seek and save a crowd. He came for the lost—one at a time. Zacchaeus was one name, up one tree, and Jesus stopped for him. That's the whole model: love people one at a time (Wreck the Roof). So here's the question tonight—who's your one? Not the ten students you'd love to reach someday. One lost student, by name, that God is putting on your heart. Have every leader say a name out loud. That student is at the 'Come & See' chair—they don't know Jesus yet, and they may not know they're wanted. Your job isn't to close the deal this week. It's to seek. Pursue. Show up. What's one specific way you could move toward your one this week?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Go around and pray for each 'one' by name. Ask God to go ahead of you, to soften that student's heart, and to give you courage to pursue them like Jesus pursued you.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Write your one's name where you'll see it. Invite your team to begin praying with you. Then take a step towards them knowing Jesus as Lord and Savior.

MIS-02

REACHING THE CROWD

MANTRA **WRECK THE ROOF** | CHAIR **COME & SEE** | RHYTHM **MISSION**

BIG IDEA

Your few matter most—but every student in the room matters, and Jesus fed the whole crowd.

LUKE 9:16-17 NLT

Jesus took the five loaves and two fish, looked up toward heaven, and blessed them. Then, breaking the loaves into pieces, he kept giving the bread and fish to the disciples so they could distribute it to the people. They all ate as much as they wanted, and afterward, the disciples picked up twelve baskets of leftovers!

LEADER NOTES

Good before a big outreach night or a season with lots of new faces. Middle schoolers cluster tight—coach leaders to break up cliques gently. Name the 'invisible middle'—students who show up but never get pursued.

OPEN 2 MIN

When you walk into HSM / MSM, who do you naturally gravitate to—and who do you subtly wish to avoid?

CORE 8 MIN

Jesus invested deeply in twelve, but look at Luke 9—he didn't ignore the five thousand. He engaged the crowd. He fed them. He noticed the whole room. Here's the tension every leader lives in: your few matter most, but your group also includes students still in the crowd. The new kid nobody's talking to. The one on the edge of the circle. The friend a student dragged along who's never been to church. The crowd is full of 'ones' who haven't been claimed yet. Notice how Jesus fed them—he blessed it and handed it to the disciples to distribute. He didn't do it alone; he unleashed his people. So how do we love a whole room without losing our few? Simple stuff: learn names fast and treat every new face like they were sent to you. Partner with your few to love the crowd. Who in the 'crowd' has been slipping past you?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for eyes to see the whole room this week—the students on the edges, the first-timers, the ones nobody's claimed. Ask God to make your ministry a place where no one gets walked past.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Equip your few to start having eyes for the crowd. Extend your influence through them to ensure our ministry continues to be a place where students connect with Jesus and one another.

MIS-03

SHOWING UP AT THEIR SCHOOL

MANTRA **GRIP THE PLOW** | CHAIR **COME & SEE** | RHYTHM **MISSION**

BIG IDEA

Ministry isn't only what happens on Wednesday—it's showing up in the places students actually live.

MATTHEW 5:14-16 NLT

You are the light of the world—like a city on a hilltop that cannot be hidden. No one lights a lamp and then puts it under a basket. Instead, a lamp is placed on a stand, where it gives light to everyone in the house. In the same way, let your good deeds shine out for all to see, so that everyone will praise your heavenly Father.

LEADER NOTES

Coordinate with campus staff on school-access and safe-presence guidelines before leaders show up on campuses. MSM tweak: parents are gatekeepers—partner with them and be ready to meet them! HSM tweak: high schoolers notice who shows up and who doesn't; consistency matters more than a grand gesture.



OPEN 2 MIN

Where do students spend the most hours in a week? It's not church. Say the top spot out loud.

CORE 8 MIN

A student sees you for maybe two hours at HSM / MSM. They spend thirty-plus hours a week at school. If your ministry only happens inside the building, you're a lamp under a basket. Jesus says be a city on a hill—visible, present, out where people already are. Showing up at a student's game, play, lunch table, or graduation says something a Wednesday night or Sunday morning never could: 'You matter to me even when there's nothing in it for me.' That's Grip the Plow—focused, faithful effort that doesn't quit when it gets inconvenient. It's not about being everywhere. It's about being present somewhere that costs you something. Ask honestly: when's the last time you showed up in a student's world outside the church walls? What's one game, event, or lunch you could actually get to this month?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for open doors into students' everyday worlds—and for the schools, campuses, and neighborhoods your students walk into every day. Ask God to make you a light they can't miss.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Get one student's schedule—a game, a concert, a performance—and put it on your calendar. Then actually show up.

MIS-04

CAMP: WHO ARE YOU BRINGING?

MANTRA **WRECK THE ROOF** | CHAIR **COME & SEE** | RHYTHM **MISSION**

BIG IDEA

Camp isn't a trip to fill—it's a catalyst. The invite list should be intentional from you and your core students.

LUKE 14:23 NLT

So his master said, 'Go out into the country lanes and behind the hedges and urge anyone you find to come, so that the house will be full.'

LEADER NOTES

Run this 6-8 weeks before camp registration closes so invites have runway. Loop in staff on financial aid needs for cost barriers. MSM tweak: MS Camp (July)—parents decide, so equip leaders to invite the family, not just the student. HSM tweak: HS Camp (June)—peer invites are gold; challenge core students especially to pray for their one and get them there.



OPEN 2 MIN

Think back to a camp or retreat that changed you. What actually happened there that couldn't happen at home?

CORE 8 MIN

Camp is the most compressed discipleship opportunity we get all year—days of no distractions, real community, and space for God to move. Camp doesn't disciple students who aren't there. The master in Luke 14 doesn't say 'hope the house fills up.' He says go out and urge people to come until it's full. That's the posture for camp. Don't wait for students to sign up—build your invite list on purpose. Who most needs a week away from the noise? Who's on the fence about faith and just needs uninterrupted time? Who would a student's invite afford the chance to find Christ for the first time? Have every leader name two or three students they're personally going to invite and pursue toward camp. Then ask: what's the actual barrier for each—cost, nerves, parents—and how do we knock it down?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray by name for the students each leader wants at camp. Ask God to remove the barriers—money, fear, distraction—and to prepare hearts for what he wants to do that week.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Personally invite one student to camp this week—a real conversation, not a group announcement. Follow up on what's standing in their way.

MIS-05

THE INVITE HABIT

MANTRA **CATCH THE WIND** | CHAIR **COME & SEE** | RHYTHM **MISSION** | DISCIPLINE **EVANGELISM**

BIG IDEA

Invitation shouldn't be a hail mary; it should be intentional—attached to a relationship with the person you're inviting.

JOHN 1:45-46 NLT

Philip went to look for Nathanael and told him, 'We have found the very person Moses and the prophets wrote about! His name is Jesus, the son of Joseph from Nazareth.' 'Nazareth!' exclaimed Nathanael. 'Can anything good come from Nazareth?' 'Come and see for yourself,' Philip replied.

LEADER NOTES

Pairs well before a One Night or 1x series. Keep the practice reps in—saying the invite out loud kills the awkwardness. MSM tweak: middle schoolers invite best when it's tied to a specific fun event. HSM tweak: challenge students to own the invite habit themselves, not just leave it to leaders.

OPEN 2 MIN

When's the last time you invited someone to anything? A meal, a game, church—anything. Was it easy or awkward?

CORE 8 MIN

Nathanael was skeptical—'Can anything good come from Nazareth?' Philip didn't argue theology. He said three words: 'Come and see.' That's it. That's the invite habit. Most students who walk through our doors come because a friend or a leader simply invited them—not because of a slick flyer. Inviting feels awkward because we make it a sales pitch. It's not. It's 'come and see for yourself.' Low pressure, high warmth. This is Catch the Wind—taking the small risk and trusting the Holy Spirit to do what you can't. Here's the shift: inviting shouldn't be a special event you psych yourself up for. It should be a habit. Every week, someone gets invited. Model it, name it, celebrate it. Ask: what makes inviting feel awkward for you—and what would make it normal? Practice right now: say the invite you'd give a student out loud to the person next to you.

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for boldness to invite without overthinking it. Ask God to bring specific names to mind—and pray for the students each leader is going to say 'come and see' to.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Invite one student to something this week—group, an event, or camp. Keep it simple: 'come and see.'

MIS-06

YOUR TESTIMONY IN 3 MINUTES

CHAIR COME & SEE | RHYTHM EQUIPPING | DISCIPLINE EVANGELISM

BIG IDEA

You don't need to win a debate—you need to be ready to tell your story simply and honestly.

1 PETER 3:15 NLT

Instead, you must worship Christ as Lord of your life. And if someone asks about your hope as a believer, always be ready to explain it. But do this in a gentle and respectful way.

LEADER NOTES

Skill-building huddle. MSM tweak: keep it simple and short; middle schoolers connect with 'here's how Jesus is real to me' more than a dramatic arc. HSM tweak: high schoolers wrestle with doubt—honesty about the unfinished parts lands harder than a tidy ending.

OPEN 2 MIN

If a student asked you right now, 'Why do you actually believe this stuff?'—could you answer in two minutes without stumbling?

CORE 8 MIN

Peter says be ready—always ready—to explain your hope, gently and respectfully. Notice what he doesn't say: win the argument, have every answer, quote ten verses. Just be ready to tell why you have hope. Your testimony is the one thing no one can argue with. Nobody can debate what Jesus has done in your life. Let's build the three-minute version. Three simple parts: **(1) Before**—what my life and heart were like before Christ was real to me. **(2) How**—how I actually met Jesus and what changed. **(3) Now**—the difference he makes today, including the honest, unfinished parts. Keep it real, not polished. Students smell a script. Give leaders a couple minutes to jot down each part. As they wrap up, have them share with a neighbor.

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for courage and clarity to share your story when the moment comes. Ask God for the right opportunities this week—and for the students who need to hear that Jesus changes people.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Consider God's story and your story—Before, How, Now. Look for an opportunity to tell your story in hopes that it allows you to share God's story.

MIS-07 GATHERED & SCATTERED

MANTRA **WRECK THE ROOF** | CHAIR **FOLLOW ME** | RHYTHM **MISSION** | DISCIPLINE **EVANGELISM**

BIG IDEA

The gathering fuels the scattering. Unleashing students starts in groups and moves out to where God sovereignly places those students.

LUKE 9:1-2 NLT

One day Jesus called together his twelve disciples and gave them power and authority to cast out all demons and to heal all diseases. Then he sent them out to tell everyone about the Kingdom of God and to heal the sick.

LEADER NOTES

Good mid-semester when the ministry feels comfortable but stagnant. Don't forget that leaders modeling mission for students carries more weight than telling them to do it. How can leaders model the mission for their students?



OPEN 2 MIN

What percent of our core students are leaving MSM / HSM on mission to seek and save the lost? This number might be more important than how many students are attending our ministry.

CORE 8 MIN

Look at what Jesus did with the Twelve. He gathered them, he equipped them—and then he sent them out. Gathering was never the finish line; it was the training ground. Here's the trap in student ministry: we get so good at the gathering—great program, fun night, tight small group—that 'come in' becomes the whole point. But Jesus regularly sent his people out to do the mission themselves. A student who only ever consumes at the gathering is stuck at 'Follow Me' chair 2. The next move is being unleashed—actually doing the ministry, not just receiving it. That's Wreck the Roof: we send students out with vision to reach their lost friends one at a time. Our vision is to 'unleash the full force of the church'—and students are part of that force, not just its audience. Ask: what's one thing your students could be doing instead of just watching? Serving, inviting, leading a prayer, sharing their story? How do we send, not just gather?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for the courage to release students into real ministry instead of keeping them comfortable. Ask God to raise up sent students—and name one you want to challenge to step up.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, hand one student a real ministry role—lead a prayer at school, eat lunch on mission, share their story, serve someone. Send them, don't just gather them.

06

SECTION 06

DISCIPLESHIP & SPIRITUAL GROWTH

Growing deep, not just busy.

IN THIS SECTION

HUDDLES ON DISCIPLESHIP & SPIRITUAL GROWTH

DSC-01	Be the Branch	85
DSC-02	Catch the Wind	87
DSC-03	Wreck the Roof	89
DSC-04	Grip the Plow	91
DSC-05	Empty the Jar	93
DSC-06	Walk as Jesus Walked	95
DSC-07	Ministry Is for You, Not Just Them	97

DSC-01 BE THE BRANCH

MANTRA **BE THE BRANCH** | CHAIR **BEAR FRUIT** | RHYTHM **COMMUNITY**

BIG IDEA

You can't manufacture fruit by trying harder—you produce it by staying connected to Jesus.

JOHN 15:4-5 NLT

Remain in me, and I will remain in you. For a branch cannot produce fruit if it is severed from the vine, and you cannot be fruitful unless you remain in me. Yes, I am the vine; you are the branches. Those who remain in me, and I in them, will produce much fruit. For apart from me you can do nothing.

LEADER NOTES

Foundational mantra huddle—great to launch a semester or a mantra series. MSM/HSM tweak: Use a simpler image of a phone that only works while it's plugged in if you don't want to rip a branch off a tree.



OPEN 2 MIN

Think about the last month of ministry. Were you drawing from Jesus, or doing it on your own?

CORE 8 MIN

Read John 15:4-5. Notice what Jesus doesn't say. He doesn't say 'work harder' or 'produce more.' He says 'remain.' A branch doesn't strain to make grapes—it just stays attached. That's the whole point. This is our first mantra: Be the Branch. We value connection to Jesus over production for Jesus, and connection in community over doing it alone. Here's the trap for leaders: ministry can become the thing you do instead of the thing that flows out of your walk with Jesus. Ask honestly: is my time with students the overflow of my time with Jesus, or a substitute for it? Apart from him, Jesus says, you can do nothing—not a little, nothing that lasts. The fruit in a student's life doesn't come from your effort. It comes from a branch that stays attached to the vine.

PRAYER 3 MIN

Sit quietly for one minute—no words, just being with Jesus like a branch resting on the vine. Then pray for each other to abide before you achieve.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, reset your quiet time rhythm if needed. Ask your co-leaders to keep you accountable. Abide before you produce.

DSC-02 CATCH THE WIND

MANTRA **CATCH THE WIND** RHYTHM **MISSION**

BIG IDEA

The Holy Spirit moves where He wants—our job is to raise the sail, not control the wind.

JOHN 3:8 NLT

The wind blows wherever it wants. Just as you can hear the wind but can't tell where it comes from or where it is going, so you can't explain how people are born of the Spirit.

LEADER NOTES

Mantra huddle on the Holy Spirit—pairs well before an outreach push or a bold season. Consider where the Wind might be blowing for your whole ministry, but then also for each leader in their discipleship of students.



OPEN 2 MIN

When was a moment in ministry that clearly wasn't you—where the Spirit showed up and you were just along for the ride?

CORE 8 MIN

Read John 3:8. Jesus is talking to Nicodemus, a man who liked control and had God figured out on paper. Jesus hands him wind. You don't schedule wind. You can't manufacture it. You can only be ready for it. That's our mantra: Catch the Wind. We value risk and adventure over safety, and following the Spirit over our own tidy plan. For a leader, this is scary—because it means the best moments won't be in your plans. The Spirit might move mid-game, mid-drive, mid-conversation. Ask: where have I been playing it safe with students because a Spirit-led move felt risky? Catching the wind means saying yes before you know how it ends—praying for the kid you can't crack, asking the question that might get real, going off-script when the room shifts. You don't make the wind blow, but are you ready to put the sail up?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray a dangerous prayer together: 'Holy Spirit, wherever you're moving this week, give me the courage to follow.' Share with one other person the place you sense the wind stirring.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, take one Spirit-prompted risk you'd normally talk yourself out of—one conversation, one invite, one prayer. Raise the sail.

DSC-03 WRECK THE ROOF

MANTRA **WRECK THE ROOF** | CHAIR **COME & SEE** | RHYTHM **MISSION** | DISCIPLINE **EVANGELISM**

BIG IDEA

Do whatever it takes to get one student to Jesus—even if it means tearing the roof off.

LUKE 5:18-20 NLT

Some men came carrying a paralyzed man on a sleeping mat. They tried to take him inside to Jesus, but they couldn't reach him because of the crowd. So they went up to the roof and took off some tiles. Then they lowered the sick man on his mat down into the crowd, right in front of Jesus. Seeing their faith, Jesus said to the man, 'Young man, your sins are forgiven.'

LEADER NOTES

High-energy mantra huddle on one-at-a-time. Great after a slow stretch to re-fire up the team. MSM/HSM tweak: get visual and bring a mat. Bring the mantra to life. Make it real for the room to feel the weight.

OPEN 2 MIN

Name a time someone went way out of their way for you—beyond what was normal or convenient. What did it tell you about how they saw you?

CORE 8 MIN

Read Luke 5:18-20. Four friends. One paralyzed man. A packed house and no way in. So they climb up, rip a hole in someone else's roof, and lower their friend down through the ceiling. That's not normal. That's not polite. That's desperate love. And notice—Jesus responds to their faith, the friends' faith, and heals the man. That's our mantra: Wreck the Roof. We radically love people one at a time, and we value innovation over tradition. The roof is whatever's in the way of a student meeting Jesus—a schedule, a norm, a barrier, a 'we've always done it this way.' Ask: is there a student the normal path isn't reaching? What roof would you have to wreck to get that one kid in front of Jesus? This is one-at-a-time love. Not the crowd. Not the program. The one on the mat who can't get there alone—and the friends crazy enough to carry them.

PRAYER 3 MIN

Each leader names one student who's "stuck outside the door"—hard to reach, easy to overlook. Pray for the faith and the creativity to carry them in.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Pick the one student you named. How can you partner with your core students to get that friend in front of Jesus? Here or out there—make it happen!

DSC-04 GRIP THE PLOW

MANTRA **GRIP THE PLOW** | CHAIR **FISH FOR PEOPLE** | RHYTHM **EQUIPPING**

BIG IDEA

Whether plowing for fruit you'll get to see or for fruit someone else will get to bear some day, stay the course and keep plowing.

LUKE 9:62 NLT

But Jesus told him, 'Anyone who puts a hand to the plow and then looks back is not fit for the Kingdom of God.'

LEADER NOTES

Mantra huddle on focus and follow-through. Good mid-semester when energy drifts. MSM/HSM tweak: get visual and bring a rake (gets the point across). Show a good stance with two hands on the plow, putting your back into it. Then show how looking back breaks your stance and ultimately requires you to drop one hand.



OPEN 2 MIN

What's the thing you're most tempted to keep 'looking back' at—a comfort, a distraction, a what-if—that pulls your focus off students?

CORE 8 MIN

Read Luke 9:62. Jesus isn't being harsh for the fun of it. He's describing physics. To plow a straight furrow you have to fix your eyes ahead. Look back and the line bends. Half-in doesn't work. That's our mantra: Grip the Plow. We value intentional, focused effort over drifting, and personal engagement over just attendance. Here's the question: are you gripping the plow, or just showing up? Attendance is easy—you're in the room. Engagement is the plow—you know your students' names, their stories, where they are with Jesus, and you're driving forward with them on purpose. Looking back can be nostalgia ('remember when it was easier'), comparison, or a foot still in an old way of doing ministry. Jesus calls it: hands on the plow, eyes ahead, no looking back. Not perfection—direction. Ask: where has my grip loosened?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for focus. Each leader names one 'looking back' they're ready to let go of, and one student they want to fully engage this week. Pray it forward.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

If you've just been coming to MSM / HSM, grip the plow and make it to a Retreat or Camp. Commit to be at the rest of the events this year. Plan to take a student on a mission trip.

DSC-05 EMPTY THE JAR

MANTRA **EMPTY THE JAR** | RHYTHM **CARE** | DISCIPLINE **SERVE**

BIG IDEA

The more you know you've been forgiven, the more extravagantly you'll love—so pour it all out.

LUKE 7:44-47 NLT

Then he turned to the woman and said to Simon, 'Look at this woman kneeling here. When I entered your home, you didn't offer me water to wash the dust from my feet, but she has washed them with her tears and wiped them with her hair. You didn't greet me with a kiss, but from the time I first came in, she has not stopped kissing my feet. You neglected the courtesy of olive oil to anoint my head, but she has anointed my feet with rare perfume. I tell you, her sins—and they are many—have been forgiven, so she has shown me much love. But a person who is forgiven little shows only little love.'

LEADER NOTES

Mantra huddle on sacrificial love and worship—tender, can get emotional. Give the silence room. MSM/HSM tweak: get visual and bring an item of great value, or a jar labeled as valuable. Using the jar, have leaders write the thing that's valuable they want to pour out and place it in the jar. Dump their "valuables" as a way to signify our collective pouring out.



OPEN 2 MIN

When was the last time you gave something to God or a student that actually cost you—time, money, pride, comfort? What was it?

CORE 8 MIN

Read Luke 7:44-47. A woman crashes a dinner party and pours out a jar of perfume worth about a year's wages on Jesus' feet, wiping them with her hair while everyone watches, appalled. It's messy. It's excessive. It's not proper. And Jesus loves it—because it's real. Then he names why: 'her sins, and they are many, have been forgiven, so she has shown much love.' That's our mantra: Empty the Jar. We value sacrificial generosity, and expressive worship over polite ritual. Here's the connection for a leader: the size of your love is tied to the size of the forgiveness you feel you've received. If your worship and your ministry have gone tidy and cheap, it's often because you've forgotten how much you've been forgiven. Simon kept his jar sealed and stayed comfortable. The woman broke hers open and got named by Jesus. Ask: am I pouring out for students and for Jesus, or keeping the jar corked and safe?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Spend a quiet minute remembering what Jesus forgave in you—the real weight of it. Then let that fuel a prayer of poured-out love and thanks. Don't rush it.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, love one student in a way that costs you something—time you don't have, generosity you'll feel. Empty a little of the jar.

DSC-06 WALK AS JESUS WALKED

CHAIR **BEAR FRUIT** RHYTHM **EQUIPPING**

BIG IDEA

Students need a model to follow, not just good teaching to listen to. They'll copy how you walk, so walk like Jesus.

1 JOHN 2:6 NLT

Those who say they live in God should live their lives as Jesus did.

LEADER NOTES

Ties the 4-Chairs to the leader's own life. Convicting but should land as invitation, not shame. MSM/HSM tweak: MSM—students imitate constantly and copy energy/attitude; make that the hook. HSM—teens sniff out hypocrisy fast; lean into authenticity over performance.



OPEN 2 MIN

Finish this sentence: 'If a student copied my life exactly this week, they'd end up _____.' Be honest.

CORE 8 MIN

Read 1 John 2:6. If you claim to live in Jesus, then your life should look like His. This is the whole 4-Chairs idea in one verse—we help move students from **Come & See** to **Follow Me** to **Fishing for People** to **Bearing Fruit**, and the last two only work if there's something worth imitating. You can't disciple students to a Jesus-shaped life you're not living. They don't need you perfect; they need you honest and headed the right direction. Ask: which parts of Jesus' walk are actually showing up in mine—his prayer life, his time in the Word, his compassion, his way with the overlooked? And which parts are more talk than walk? Discipleship is 'follow me as I follow Christ.' The invitation you extend to a student is only as real as the walk they can watch. This isn't pressure to fake it. It's a call to close the gap between what you teach and how you live.

PRAYER 3 MIN

Confess honestly, in pairs, one gap between your talk and your walk. Pray for each other to close it—not by trying harder, but by walking closer to Jesus.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Pick one way Jesus walked—prayer, Scripture, kindness to an outsider—and deliberately model it in front of your students this week.

DSC-07

MINISTRY IS FOR YOU, NOT JUST THEM

CHAIR **BEAR FRUIT** | RHYTHM **RETREAT** | DISCIPLINE **BIBLE**

BIG IDEA

A leader who only reads the Bible for others will dry up. A leader planted along a spiritual riverbank will lead from overflow.

PSALM 1:2-3 NLT

But they delight in the law of the Lord, meditating on it day and night. They are like trees planted along the riverbank, bearing fruit each season. Their leaves never wither, and they prosper in all they do.

LEADER NOTES

A refuel week on the leader's personal Word intake. Pairs well with the Eremos/Solitary Retreat rhythm. Prioritize a leader's spiritual health over their volunteering for your ministry. Don't just say it, mean it.



OPEN 2 MIN

Not counting prep for group—when did you last open your Bible just to feed yourself? Think it, don't share it.

CORE 8 MIN

Read Psalm 1:2-3. The blessed person isn't the busiest or the most gifted—it's the one who delights in God's Word and meditates on it, and the result is a tree by the river that never dries up. Here's the leader trap: your Bible becomes a tool. You open it to build a lesson, prep a talk, answer a student—always for someone else, never for you. And slowly you go dry, because you're only ever pouring out. You can't give what you don't have. A tree planted by the river isn't straining to make fruit; it's just close to the water, all the time. That's the difference between reading the Word for material and delighting in it for life. Ask: is my own Scripture intake feeding me, or just fueling output? This is why Jesus often withdrew to be with the Father. Establish your feeding rhythm first so your students receive the overflow.

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray Psalm 1 over each other—that you'd be trees by the river, delighting in the Word, never withered. Name one time this week you'll come to the river just for you.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, read Scripture for yourself three times with zero ministry agenda—not to teach it, just to be fed. Start small and real.

07

SECTION 07

SKILLS & TRAINING

Sharpening the craft of leading.

IN THIS SECTION

HUDDLES ON SKILLS & TRAINING

SKL-01	Names & the First Five Minutes	101
SKL-02	Connecting with Parents	103
SKL-03	Safety & Wisdom	105
SKL-04	Handling Hard Questions	107
SKL-05	On Time & Prepared	109
SKL-06	Creating a Safe Place in Group	111

SKL-01

NAMES & THE FIRST FIVE MINUTES

CHAIR COME & SEE | RHYTHM CARE

BIG IDEA

A student decides in the first five minutes whether they were expected or just allowed in—and hearing their name is how they know.

JOHN 10:3 NLT

The gatekeeper opens the gate for him, and the sheep recognize his voice and come to him. He calls his own sheep by name and leads them out.

LEADER NOTES

Hospitality craft huddle—the pre-group minutes, not the group itself. MSM/HSM tweak: MSM—new kids arrive nervous and with a parent hovering; greet both. HSM—students test whether anyone notices them before they decide to come back; the door and the back row of chairs are the mission field.

OPEN 2 MIN

Think of a place where somebody knows your name and expects you. How does walking in there feel different? Name the place.

CORE 8 MIN

Read John 10:3. The shepherd calls his own sheep by name—not 'hey buddy,' not 'the tall one.' Name. In a room full of teenagers, a name is the difference between being seen and being counted. And the window is short: most students decide in the first five minutes whether they were expected or just allowed in. So treat the pre-group minutes as the job, not the wait before the job. A few crafts to practice: **(1)** Learn names on purpose—say it back when you hear it, use it twice in the conversation, write it down after. If you blank, own it: 'Tell me your name again—I want to get it right.' **(2)** Scan the edges—the new kid isn't in the middle of the room; they're by the wall, on their phone, pretending to be busy. Go to them. **(3)** Make the introduction—a new student needs one friend more than they need you; connect them by name to a student like them. **(4)** Arrive with a list—two or three students you're looking for tonight, by name, before they walk in.

PRAYER 3 MIN

Thank God that he calls each of your students by name. Pray for the student on the edge of your group—say their name out loud—and for eyes to spot whoever's new this week.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, greet every student in your group by name before group starts—and if someone new shows up, learn their name and introduce them to one student before they sit down.

SKL-02 CONNECTING WITH PARENTS

RHYTHM **COMMUNITY**

BIG IDEA

You're not replacing the home—you're partnering with it, because parents are the primary disciple-makers.

DEUTERONOMY 6:6-7 NLT

And you must commit yourselves wholeheartedly to these commands that I am giving you today. Repeat them again and again to your children. Talk about them when you are at home and when you are on the road, when you are going to bed and when you are getting up.

LEADER NOTES

Skill huddle on home partnership. MSM/HSM tweak: MSM—parents are highly engaged and want communication; make proactive positive contact the norm. HSM—students push for independence, so honor that while still keeping parents informed and partnered per campus policy.

OPEN 2 MIN

Do you know the parents of the students in your group? Not 'seen them'—actually know a name. How many?

CORE 8 MIN

Read Deuteronomy 6:6-7. Notice who God hands the discipleship job to: parents, at home, all day long—driving, eating, bedtime, morning. That's the front line. We are not it. We get a couple hours a week; a parent gets the other 166. Which reframes our whole role: we're not replacing the home, we're partnering with it. Practically, that means a parent should hear from you before there's a problem—a quick 'your kid said something awesome tonight' text builds trust you'll draw on later. It means you point students back toward honoring their parents, not around them. And it means you resource the home: what's the series about, what could a parent talk about at dinner. A few honest realities: some students don't have a Deuteronomy 6 home, and for them you may be the closest thing to it—that's holy ground. Ask: which parent could I reach out to this week to start a real partnership?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for the homes behind your students—the strong ones and the broken ones. Ask God to make you a partner to parents, not a competitor. Name one family.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Reach out to one parent this week with something positive about their kid—no ask attached, just encouragement. Start the partnership.

SKL-03 SAFETY & WISDOM

RHYTHM **EQUIPPING**

BIG IDEA

Loving students well means protecting them—wise guardrails aren't a lack of faith, they're an act of it.

MATTHEW 10:16 NLT

Look, I am sending you out as sheep among wolves. So be as shrewd as snakes and harmless as doves.

LEADER NOTES

Safety huddle—this does not replace ministry safe training. If any leader raises a live concern, a staff member handles it immediately, not the group. Utilize a form that allows you to track leaders awareness of our safety guardrails.

OPEN 2 MIN

Name one guardrail—a rule or habit—that's actually there to protect people, that you're glad exists. Why does it matter?

CORE 8 MIN

Read Matthew 10:16. Jesus tells his people to be shrewd as snakes and harmless as doves—wise and clean, alert and above reproach, at the same time. That's the posture for anyone working with minors. Guardrails aren't a sign you don't trust people; they protect students, protect you, and protect the ministry's witness. Walk through the general wisdom together (and always defer to your staff): **(1)** Two-adult / never-alone—avoid being one-on-one with a student behind a closed door or out of sight. **(2)** Visible and transparent—meet in public, keep communication in channels others can see, loop parents and staff in. **(3)** Appropriate touch and language—err way to the safe side. **(4)** Digital wisdom—same rules apply online as in person. And the big one: if a student discloses harm, or you have a concern about their safety, you are not the last stop. Your job is to listen, stay calm, keep the student safe, and report it up to campus staff right away—do not investigate, do not promise total secrecy, do not sit on it. Ask: does everyone here know exactly who to tell and how, at our campus?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Thank God that students are worth protecting. Pray for wisdom, clean hearts, and the courage to speak up if you ever need to. Ask him to keep this ministry safe.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, confirm you know your campus's reporting steps—who to tell and how—before you ever need them. If you don't know, ask staff this week.

SKL-04 HANDLING HARD QUESTIONS

RHYTHM **EQUIPPING**

BIG IDEA

Doubts aren't a threat to faith, hidden doubts are. 'I don't know, let's find out together' is a powerful, honest response to discover together.

2 TIMOTHY 2:15 NLT

Work hard so you can present yourself to God and receive his approval. Be a good worker, one who does not need to be ashamed and who correctly explains the word of truth.

LEADER NOTES

Skill huddle on apologetics posture, not content—the point is how you respond, not memorizing answers. The role-play makes it stick.

OPEN 2 MIN

What's the hardest question a student has ever thrown at you—the one that made you sweat? Say it out loud.

CORE 8 MIN

Read 2 Timothy 2:15. Paul calls Timothy to work hard and rightly handle the truth—not to fake expertise. Here's the freeing part: 'I don't know' is allowed. In fact it's often the most trustworthy thing you can say. When a student asks the big one—Why does God let bad things happen? Is my friend in hell? How do we know the Bible's true?—panic makes leaders do two bad things: bluff a shaky answer, or shut the question down. Don't. Try this instead: **(1)** Honor the question—'That's a really good question, I'm glad you asked it.' **(2)** Be honest about your limits—'I don't have a clean answer for that.' **(3)** Point to the bigger yes—even when the details are fuzzy, you can say what you do know about who God is. **(4)** Chase it together—'Let me look into it and let's talk next week,' then actually follow up. Loop in staff for heavy ones if needed. Doubts aren't a threat to faith; hidden doubts are. A student who feels safe asking you the hard thing is a student who trusts you. Practice: have someone lob a hard question and let a leader model the honest response.

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for humility to not fake it and courage to keep learning. Name one hard question you want to grow in answering, and ask God for wisdom to handle it.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

If a student asked you something you couldn't answer recently, go find out this week—and follow back up with them. Model 'let's find out.'

SKL-05 ON TIME & PREPARED

RHYTHM **EQUIPPING**

BIG IDEA

Showing up early and ready is a spiritual act—reliability is how students learn they can count on you.

COLOSSIANS 3:23 NLT

Work willingly at whatever you do, as though you were working for the Lord rather than for people.

LEADER NOTES

A no-nonsense reliability huddle—say the quiet part kindly. Best delivered as encouragement, not a scolding. MSM/HSM tweak: MSM—early arrival matters a ton for the pre-program chaos. HSM—students read your consistency as whether you actually care; name that.

OPEN 2 MIN

Be honest—are you usually the leader who's early and set, or the one sliding in as it starts?

CORE 8 MIN

Read Colossians 3:23. Whatever you do, do it as if for the Lord. That verse doesn't just cover the spiritual highlights—it covers being on time. It covers reading the group content before you walk in. It covers knowing which students you'll look for tonight. Here's the truth we don't say enough: reliability is a ministry. When you're consistently early, students learn the room is safe and steady before they even arrive. When you're prepared, the night doesn't ride on adrenaline and luck. When you follow through on what you said, a student learns that adults keep their word—which quietly teaches them something about God. The flip side stings: chronic lateness and winging it tell students they're low on your list, even if you'd never say it. This isn't about perfection or performance. It's about faithfulness in the unglamorous stuff. Ask: what's the one prep or punctuality habit that, if I fixed it, would most bless my students and my team?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray that God would help you serve faithfully in the small, unseen things—that being early and ready would be worship. Name the one habit you're owning.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, show up at least ten minutes early and fully prepped—content read, students in mind, phone away. Be the steady presence in the room. Sit with your students.

SKL-06

CREATING A SAFE PLACE IN GROUP

CHAIR **FISH FOR PEOPLE** RHYTHM **CARE**

BIG IDEA

When it comes to creating a safe place for students, know the difference between confidentiality and concern.

PROVERBS 11:13 NLT

A gossip goes around telling secrets, but those who are trustworthy can keep a confidence.

LEADER NOTES

Care + safety huddle. Pairs naturally with SKL-03; both must defer to campus policy and required child-protection training. If a live concern surfaces in huddle, a staff member handles it right away, not the group.

OPEN 2 MIN

Think of an adult you trusted as a teenager with something real. What made you sure they'd keep it? Name one thing.

CORE 8 MIN

Read Proverbs 11:13. Trust is built by leaders who can keep a confidence and broken by leaders who can't. When a student opens up to you, you're holding something sacred—and how you handle it decides whether they, and their friends, ever open up again. So keep the ordinary stuff private. Don't turn a student's struggle into a prayer-request headline or a story you tell to look invested. Even 'we should pray for someone' can out a kid—guard names. But here's the crucial line every leader has to know: confidentiality has a hard limit. Some things are not yours to keep secret. If a student tells you they're being hurt or abused, thinking about harming themselves or someone else, or is in real danger—that is a concern, not a confidence, and it goes to campus staff immediately. Never promise a student 'I won't tell anyone' before you hear what it is; instead say, 'I care about you too much to keep you unsafe, so if you're in danger I have to get the right people to help.' You're not betraying them by escalating—you're loving them well and following our safety process. Ask each other: do you know your campus's line between 'keep it' and 'report it,' and who you report to?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for wisdom to be trustworthy with students' stories—private where you can be, and wise enough to escalate when you must. Ask God to make you safe and honest.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

This week, make sure you can clearly state your campus's line between confidence and concern—and exactly who you escalate to. If it's fuzzy, ask staff.

08

SECTION 08

VISION & CULTURE

The why beneath the what.

IN THIS SECTION

HUDDLES ON VISION & CULTURE

VIS-01	Why We Exist	115
VIS-02	Where We're Going	117
VIS-03	143,556	119
VIS-04	How Jesus Did It	121
VIS-05	One at a Time	123
VIS-06	We Win When...	125

VIS-01 WHY WE EXIST

MANTRA **BE THE BRANCH** RHYTHM **COMMUNITY**

BIG IDEA

Everything we do comes down to two connections: people to Jesus, and people to one another.

MATTHEW 22:37-39 NLT

Jesus replied, 'You must love the Lord your God with all your heart, all your soul, and all your mind.' This is the first and greatest commandment. A second is equally important: 'Love your neighbor as yourself.'

LEADER NOTES

Foundational vision huddle—great for onboarding new leaders or resetting a team that's drifted into program-mode. Ties directly to the church mission statement. MSM tweak: keep 'connect up and across' concrete—a middle schooler gets it as 'closer to God, better friends.' HSM tweak: challenge leaders on whether their group is actually community or just a room of individuals.

OPEN 2 MIN

In one sentence, why do you think our student ministry exists? Don't overthink it—just in your own words answer.

CORE 8 MIN

It's easy to get so busy running the ministry that we forget why we're here at all. So let's get it clear. Our mission at Southeast is 'connecting people to Jesus and to one another.' That's not marketing—it's straight out of Jesus' words. When they asked him the greatest commandment, he gave two: love God, and love your neighbor. Vertical and horizontal. Up and across. That's the whole thing. Every game, every small group, every follow-up serves one of those two connections. If a student walks away more connected to Jesus and more connected to real community, we did our job. If we ran a flawless program and neither of those happened, we missed it. And notice—you can't connect students to a Jesus you're not connected to yourself. That's Be the Branch: stay attached to the vine, or you've got nothing to hand them. Gut-check: is your leadership connecting students up to Jesus and across to each other—or are you just volunteering some time?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray that your ministry would actually connect students to Jesus and to one another this week. Ask God to keep each of you connected to him first—branches on the vine—so you have something real to give.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Pick one student this week and intentionally deepen one connection—either point them toward Jesus, or pull them into real community.

VIS-02 WHERE WE'RE GOING

MANTRA **GRIP THE PLOW** RHYTHM **MISSION**

BIG IDEA

The mission is bigger than a good program—we're making disciples, and Jesus is with us the whole way.

MATTHEW 28:19-20 NLT

Therefore, go and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and the Son and the Holy Spirit. Teach these new disciples to obey all the commands I have given you. And be sure of this: I am with you always, even to the end of the age.

LEADER NOTES

Pairs naturally after VIS-01 (mission) as the vision half. Good for casting long-term aim early in a semester. MSM tweak: 'making disciples' can feel abstract—frame it as 'helping this student take their next step with Jesus.' HSM tweak: push toward multiplication—high schoolers can start discipling younger students now.



OPEN 2 MIN

Picture a student in your group five years from now. What do you hope is actually true about their life?

CORE 8 MIN

Last time we talked about why we exist. Tonight: where we're going. Our vision at Southeast is to 'unleash the full force of the church to love people one at a time.' That comes from Jesus' final command—go and make disciples. Not just make attenders. Not make fans. Disciples: people who follow Jesus and then help others follow him too. Notice the verbs: go, make, baptize, teach. It's active. It moves. This is Grip the Plow—hand on the plow, eyes forward, not looking back or drifting off the row. Making disciples is long, unglamorous, faithful work, and it's the whole point. Here's the vision for your group: not just students who show up, but students who follow Jesus and start reaching their friends. And catch the last line—'I am with you always.' You are not carrying this vision alone. Jesus is in it with you to the end. Ask: are you aiming your group at making disciples, or just at making it through group?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for the long-game vision—students who don't just attend but follow Jesus and make disciples themselves. Thank God that he's with you always, and ask for the endurance to keep your hand on the plow.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Name the next disciple-making step for one student this week—a next step toward following Jesus—and take one action toward it.

VIS-03

143,556

MANTRA **WRECK THE ROOF** | CHAIR **COME & SEE** | RHYTHM **MISSION**

BIG IDEA

There are 143,556 students in our region and most don't know Jesus—that number should move us to pray and be mobilized.

MATTHEW 9:36-38 NLT

When he saw the crowds, he had compassion on them because they were confused and helpless, like sheep without a shepherd. He said to his disciples, 'The harvest is great, but the workers are few. So pray to the Lord who is in charge of the harvest; ask him to send more workers into his fields.'

LEADER NOTES

High-impact vision huddle—the number does the work; say it slowly and let it land. Great before an outreach push or a leader-recruiting season. Localize it—'how many of those are at [fill in] middle school?' Help leaders own challenging their students to see themselves as workers in the harvest, not just part of it.



OPEN 2 MIN

Guess how many students live in our region. Just throw out a number before I tell you.

CORE 8 MIN

Here's the real number: 143,556 students in our region. And most of them don't know Jesus. Sit with that for a second. That's not a crowd you can picture—it's a stadium many times over, full of middle and high schoolers who are, in Jesus' words, 'confused and helpless, like sheep without a shepherd.' Look at what that number did to Jesus in Matthew 9. He didn't get overwhelmed and he didn't get numb. He had compassion. His spirit moved. Then he did two things: he named the problem—the harvest is huge, the workers are few—and he told his disciples to pray for more workers. That's the tension we live in. The number is too big to feel personal, but it changes one student at a time. This is Wreck the Roof—you can't reach 143,556, but you can love the one in front of you. The way you keep a huge number from crushing you is you let it fuel compassion, and you let compassion drive you to pray and to pursue your one. Which are you more tempted toward—feeling overwhelmed, or going numb? What would compassion actually look like this week?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray Jesus' own prayer: 'Lord, the harvest is great and the workers are few—send more workers.' Pray for the 143,556, pray for more leaders to be raised up, and pray for compassion that turns into action.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Let the number drive one action this week: pursue your one, invite someone new, or recruit one more adult to help reach students.

VIS-04 HOW JESUS DID IT

MANTRA **BE THE BRANCH** | CHAIR **FISH FOR PEOPLE** | RHYTHM **EQUIPPING**

BIG IDEA

Jesus' method was simple: he picked a few, spent time with them, then sent them out—and it still works today.

MARK 3:14 NLT

Then he appointed twelve of them and called them his apostles. They were to accompany him, and he would send them out to preach.

LEADER NOTES

Core methodology huddle—this is the engine of the whole ministry model. Great for training new leaders on the 'why' behind small groups. Small groups is one piece of the objective, their few, being sent, and so much more extends beyond group.

OPEN 2 MIN

If you had to reach the whole world with a message and only three years to do it, how would you start?

CORE 8 MIN

Jesus had the biggest mission in history and about three years to launch it. Watch how he did it, because it's shockingly simple. Mark 3:14 gives the whole strategy in one verse. He appointed twelve. Not an army—twelve. And the two-part purpose: 'to accompany him' and 'to send them out.' Be with, send out. That's the 'How Jesus Did It' model we run on. He chose a few, engaged the crowd, and always invested in a few over the many. The middle piece is the one we skip—'to accompany him.' Before he ever sent them, they just spent time with him. Being with him was the training. That's the 'Follow me' challenge—a student isn't ready to be sent until they've spent real time close to a leader who's close to Jesus. And you can only pass on what you've got—Be the Branch—so your own 'with Jesus' time is the source of it all. Ask: are you doing ministry AT your students, or WITH them? Which of your students needs more 'with you' time before they're ready to be sent?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for a 'with' ministry, not just an 'at' ministry. Ask God to help you invest deeply in a few—and to keep you close to Jesus so you have something worth passing on.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Pick one student and get intentional 'with' time this week—a meal, a ride, a hangout. Presence over program.

VIS-05 ONE AT A TIME

MANTRA **WRECK THE ROOF** | CHAIR **FISH FOR PEOPLE** | RHYTHM **MISSION**

BIG IDEA

Jesus impacted the few to reach the masses. Both matter, but the strategy starts one at a time.

LUKE 15:4-6 NLT

If a man has a hundred sheep and one of them gets lost, what will he do? Won't he leave the ninety-nine others in the wilderness and go to search for the one that is lost until he finds it? And when he has found it, he will joyfully carry it home on his shoulders. When he arrives, he will call together his friends and neighbors, saying, 'Rejoice with me because I have found my lost sheep.'

LEADER NOTES

Reinforces the church vision ('one at a time') and pairs well with VIS-03 and MIS-01. Good antidote to a numbers-obsessed season. Coach leaders to notice the one who's suddenly gone silent. 'Lost' can mean physically absent or spiritually checked out while still showing up; help leaders see both.

OPEN 2 MIN

Would you rather your group be big and shallow, or small and deep? Be honest about which one actually excites you.

CORE 8 MIN

Here's a strange math problem from Jesus. A shepherd has a hundred sheep, loses one, and leaves the ninety-nine to go after the single lost one. On paper that's terrible business. Ninety-nine percent retention and he risks it for one percent. But that's exactly the heart of God—and the vision of Southeast: to love people one at a time. We live in a numbers culture. Big room, big count, big win. Jesus flips it. He invested in a few, not to reach fewer people, but because depth in a few is how you actually reach many. The lost sheep isn't a statistic to him—it's the one he carries home on his shoulders, the one he throws a party over. This is Wreck the Roof: one at a time is not a consolation prize, it's the strategy. And that one student you go after moves from the edges towards truly following Jesus—carried close, known. Ask yourself: are you tempted to chase the count, or to go deep with the ones God's actually given you? Who's your one lost sheep right now?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for the one—the student on the edges, drifting, or lost. Ask God for a shepherd's heart that would leave the ninety-nine to carry that one home, and to feel his joy when they come.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Go after one 'lost sheep' this week—a student who's drifting, missing, or on the edges. Pursue them personally, no program required.

VIS-06

WE WIN WHEN...

MANTRA **GRIP THE PLOW** | CHAIR **FOLLOW ME** | RHYTHM **EQUIPPING**

BIG IDEA

The win isn't attendance or hype—we win when a student takes a next step toward Christ.

COLOSSIANS 1:28-29 NLT

So we tell others about Christ, warning everyone and teaching everyone with all the wisdom God has given us. We want to present them to God, perfect in their relationship to Christ. That's why I work and struggle so hard, depending on Christ's mighty power that works within me.

LEADER NOTES

Defines the win for the whole ministry—great for calibrating a team obsessed with attendance or hype. MSM tweak: next steps are small and frequent—a first-time prayer out loud is huge. HSM tweak: next steps get deeper and more costly—surrender, baptism, leading others; help leaders name the real one.

OPEN 2 MIN

How do you usually measure whether a HSM / MSM 'went well'? Say your honest metric.

CORE 8 MIN

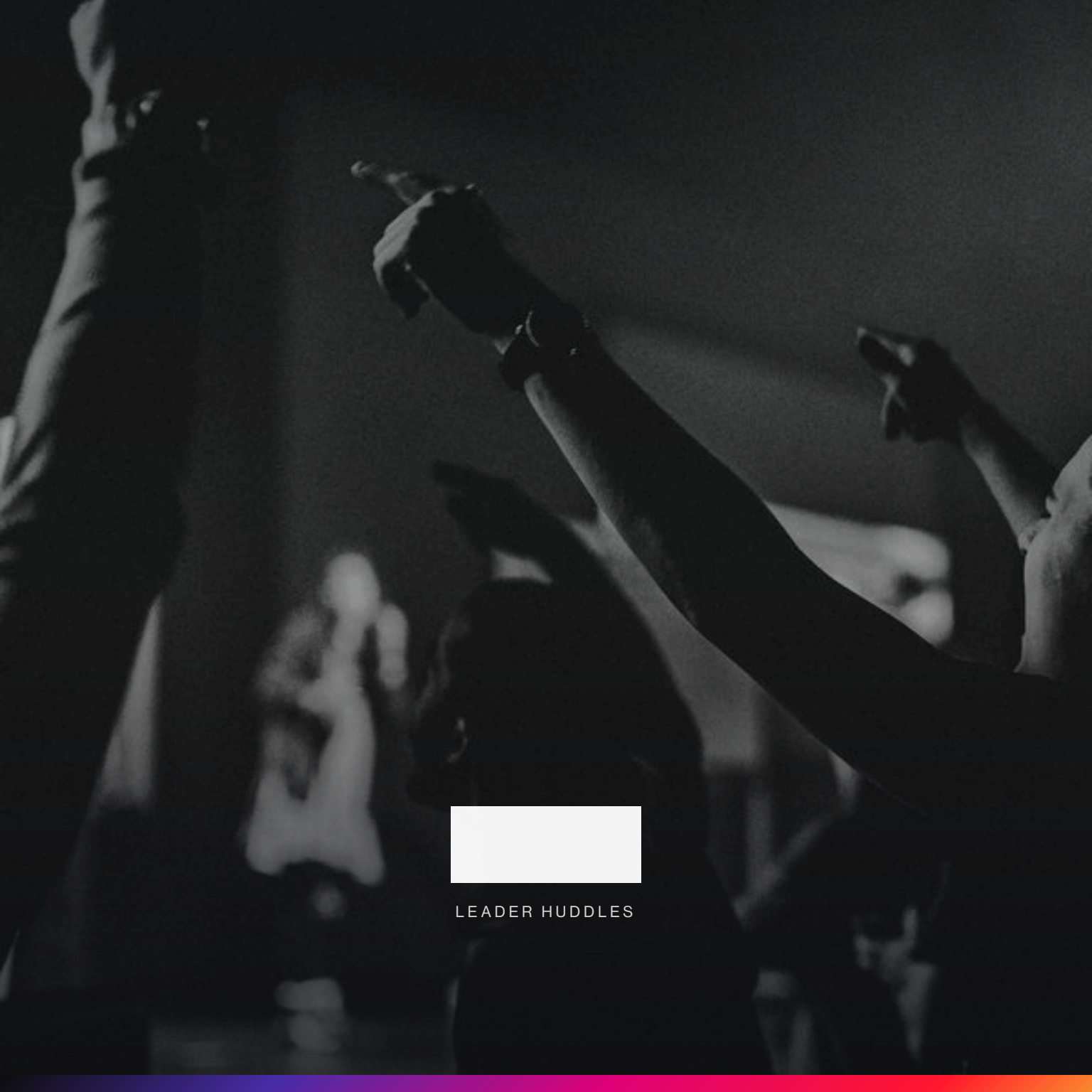
Every leader keeps score somehow. Usually it's the easy metrics: how many showed up, was it electric, did they have fun, did it run smooth. Those aren't bad—but they're not the win. Paul tells us the actual scoreboard in Colossians 1. His goal? 'To present everyone perfect in their relationship to Christ.' Growth in Jesus. Movement toward him. So here's our win, plain and simple: a student takes a next step toward Christ. That's it. That's the scoreboard. A next step is a first prayer, an honest question, a decision to follow, coming back after a hard week, choosing to invite a friend, getting baptized. Notice—a smaller, quieter night where one student took a real step toward Jesus was a bigger win than a packed, hyped night where nobody moved an inch. Paul says he works and struggles hard for this—that's Grip the Plow, staying with the slow work of growth even when it's not flashy. And catch the fuel: 'depending on Christ's mighty power that works within me.' You don't manufacture next steps; you cooperate with what God's already doing. Ask: what next step is God nudging one of your students toward right now, and how do you help them take it?

PRAYER 3 MIN

Pray for real next steps in specific students—name them. Ask God to give you eyes to measure the right things, and lean on his power, not your effort, to move students toward Christ.

THIS WEEK 2 MIN

Name the next step for one student this week—first prayer, hard question, decision, coming back—and take one action to help them take it.



LEADER HUDDLES